

Validation Evidence Relevance Module (VERM)

Architecture Ecosystem: Structured Reality Standards™

Architecture Family: VALIDOS® — Validation Governance Architecture

Parent Standard: Validation Evidence Fitness Standard (VEFS)

Operational Layer: Validation Evidence Fitness Governance Layer

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Governed Space: Validation Evidence Relevance

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· ORA™ · AGA™ · AIG® · CLIA® · MGIA™ · ASGA™ · RIS™

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Canonical Language: English (UCL™)

Governed Space

Validation Evidence Relevance

Canonical Definition

Validation Evidence Relevance Module (VERM) defines the governance framework for determining whether candidate evidence possesses a sufficiently direct, meaningful, and methodologically defensible relationship to the specific Validation Object, Validation Criterion, evidence requirement, Validation Method, Validation Purpose, and Validation Scope for which it is intended to provide validation support.

It establishes the conditions under which available information may be recognized as **Relevant Validation Evidence** rather than merely information associated with the general subject of validation.

Operational Role

VERM serves as the first evidence-qualification gate within the Validation Evidence Fitness Standard.

Its primary question is:

Does this evidence actually address the validation question for which it is being considered?

The governed progression is:

**Evidence Requirement → Candidate Evidence → Relevance Relationship →
Relevance Assessment → Relevant Validation Evidence**

VERM does not determine whether the evidence is sufficient, complete, representative, timely, or reliable.

It determines whether the evidence has a legitimate reason to participate in the validation at all.

Module Operational Space

VERM governs:

- evidence relevance,
 - evidence-to-object relevance,
 - evidence-to-criterion relevance,
 - evidence-to-requirement relevance,
 - evidence-to-method relevance,
 - evidence-to-purpose relevance,
 - evidence-to-scope relevance,
 - direct relevance,
 - indirect relevance,
 - supporting relevance,
 - contextual relevance,
 - relevance strength,
 - relevance boundaries,
 - relevance conditions,
 - relevance limitations,
 - relevance conflicts,
 - irrelevant evidence exclusion,
 - relevance change,
 - and relevance traceability.
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Module Function

VERM applies when evidence has been identified as potentially useful to a governed validation.

Its function is to prevent:

- evidence being included merely because it concerns the same general topic,
 - large evidence volumes creating artificial validation confidence,
 - technically sophisticated evidence being assumed relevant,
 - authoritative documents being treated as evidence for questions they do not answer,
 - evidence supporting one criterion being silently transferred to another,
 - evidence about one Validation Object being attributed to another,
 - contextual association being mistaken for direct evidentiary support,
 - supporting evidence being represented as determinative evidence,
 - and irrelevant evidence obscuring material Evidence Gaps.
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Candidate Evidence

A **Candidate Evidence Item** is any information, observation, measurement, record, dataset, result, document, trace, analysis, or other material proposed for use within validation.

Candidate status does not establish relevance.

The evidence must first be connected to an identifiable validation requirement.

The governing relationship is:

Validation Criterion → Evidence Requirement → Candidate Evidence

Only then can relevance be meaningfully assessed.

Evidence-to-Object Relevance

Evidence must relate to the Validation Object established within VALIDOS®.

VERM examines whether the evidence concerns:

- the actual object,
- the relevant object component,
- the applicable object version,
- the appropriate configuration,
- the relevant operational state,
- or another materially connected representation.

Evidence about a similar object does not automatically constitute evidence about the Validation Object.

Evidence-to-Criterion Relevance

The strongest relevance relationship exists when evidence directly contributes to examination of a defined Validation Criterion.

VERM asks:

- Which criterion does this evidence support?
- What characteristic does it reveal?
- What validation condition does it help examine?
- What would be lost if this evidence were removed?
- Does it materially affect the ability to evaluate the criterion?

Evidence without an identifiable criterion relationship should not

automatically enter the qualified evidence basis.

Evidence-to-Requirement Relevance

A Validation Criterion may create several specific evidence requirements.

Evidence may therefore be relevant not merely to the criterion generally, but to a particular evidentiary need.

For example:

Criterion: System remains stable under infrastructure degradation.

Possible evidence requirements may include:

- degraded-network observations,
- failover logs,
- recovery-time measurements,
- operational-state transitions,
- or failure-response records.

A normal-operation performance report may concern the same system but remain irrelevant to these specific requirements.

Evidence-to-Method Relevance

Evidence must also be usable by, produced through, or interpretable within the applicable Validation Method where required.

A method may require:

- quantitative measurements,
- observational records,
- structured datasets,
- controlled experimental results,
- simulation outputs,
- expert findings,
- or another evidence form.

Evidence may therefore be relevant to the criterion but unusable within the selected methodological pathway.

VERM keeps this relationship visible.

Evidence-to-Purpose Relevance

Evidence relevance can change according to Validation Purpose.

Evidence suitable for:

research exploration

may not provide meaningful support for: **deployment authorization**.

Likewise, evidence useful for:

performance comparison

may be irrelevant to:

safety validation.

VERM therefore evaluates relevance relative to the actual reason validation is being performed.

Evidence-to-Scope Relevance

Validation Scope establishes where the validation conclusion is intended to apply.

VERM determines whether evidence falls within or legitimately contributes to that scope.

Evidence outside the approved scope may still provide contextual information.

However, contextual usefulness must not automatically be represented as direct validation support.

Direct Evidence Relevance

Evidence has **Direct Relevance** when it directly observes, measures, demonstrates, tests, or otherwise informs the condition represented by a Validation Criterion.

Examples may include:

- measured system behavior,
- direct test results,
- operational observations,
- controlled experimental outcomes,
- or records directly documenting the condition under examination.

Direct relevance does not automatically establish evidence sufficiency or reliability.

Indirect Evidence Relevance

Evidence has **Indirect Relevance** when it contributes to understanding a Validation Criterion through an inferential relationship rather

than direct observation.

Indirect evidence may be legitimate.

However, the inferential relationship must remain visible.

Indirect evidence must not silently be represented as direct evidence.

Supporting Evidence

Some evidence does not independently establish a validation condition but strengthens interpretation of other evidence.

Supporting evidence may:

- provide context,
- explain an observation,
- corroborate a relationship,
- identify environmental conditions,
- establish chronology,
- or support methodological interpretation.

VERM allows supporting evidence while preserving its actual role.

Contextual Evidence

Contextual evidence may be important without directly supporting a Validation Criterion.

For example, information concerning:

- operating environment,
- organizational conditions,
- external events,
- system dependencies,
- or regulatory circumstances

may help explain validation evidence.

VERM distinguishes:

Evidence that validates

from:

Evidence that helps interpret validation.

This prevents contextual information from artificially increasing perceived evidentiary strength.

Relevance Strength

Where useful, evidence relevance may be characterized according to the strength of its relationship to the validation requirement.

Possible classifications may include:

Directly Relevant

Materially Relevant

Supporting

Contextual

Marginal

Irrelevant

These classifications do not represent evidence quality.

They describe the nature and strength of the relevance relationship.

Relevance Boundaries

Relevant evidence should remain bounded to the condition it can legitimately support.

For example:

Evidence demonstrating system performance at temperatures between 10°C and 30°C may be relevant within that operating range.

It should not automatically support conclusions concerning operation at -20°C.

VERM therefore prevents relevance from expanding beyond the conditions represented by the evidence.

Relevance Transfer

Evidence may sometimes be transferred between:

- versions,
- configurations,
- environments,
- populations,
- jurisdictions,
- or related Validation Objects.

Transfer requires an identifiable methodological basis.

Similarity alone does not establish transferable relevance.

Where material differences exist, evidence may become:

- conditionally relevant,
- contextually relevant,
- or irrelevant.

Relevance and Correlation

Evidence may correlate with a Validation Criterion without directly demonstrating it.

VERM therefore distinguishes correlation from evidentiary relevance sufficient for a specific inference.

For example:

A system's historical reliability may be relevant to a reliability assessment.

It does not necessarily prove future reliability under materially changed operating conditions.

The inference boundary must remain visible.

Relevance Conflict

Different evaluators or methodologies may disagree about whether evidence is relevant.

VERM requires material relevance disagreement to remain visible.

A relevance conflict may require:

- methodological review,
- criterion clarification,
- scope clarification,
- additional evidence,
- or later governance escalation.

Evidence should not be silently excluded merely because its implications are inconvenient.

Irrelevant Evidence Exclusion

Evidence determined to be irrelevant should not contribute to validation confidence.

However, exclusion should remain traceable where the evidence was materially considered.

This allows later review to determine:

- what was excluded,
- why it was excluded,
- which criterion was considered,
- and whether the exclusion remained justified.

Evidence Volume and Relevance

VERM establishes:

Evidence volume cannot compensate for lack of relevance.

One hundred irrelevant evidence items do not collectively become relevant.

Likewise, repeated evidence supporting one criterion does not compensate for missing evidence supporting another material criterion.

This principle protects validation from evidentiary inflation.

Relevance Before Sufficiency

VERM establishes an important sequencing rule:

Relevance should be established before evidence sufficiency is assessed.

It is methodologically weak to ask:

Do we have enough evidence?

before determining:

Does this evidence actually answer the validation question?

Only relevant evidence should contribute meaningfully to later sufficiency and completeness assessments.

Relevance Status

Candidate evidence may receive a relevance classification such as:

Relevant

The evidence possesses a sufficiently meaningful relationship to the defined validation requirement.

Conditionally Relevant

The evidence is relevant only under specified assumptions, contexts, boundaries, or inferential conditions.

Relevance Undetermined

Available information is insufficient to establish relevance.

Irrelevant

The evidence does not materially contribute to the defined validation requirement.

These statuses remain attached to the specific evidence-to-validation relationship.

Relevance Is Relationship-Specific

VALIDOS® establishes:

Evidence relevance is not a universal property of evidence.

The same evidence item may be:

Relevant to Criterion A,

Supporting to Criterion B,

and:

Irrelevant to Criterion C.

Relevance must therefore be represented as a relationship rather than a permanent label attached to the evidence itself.

Relevance Change Governance

Evidence relevance may change when:

- the Validation Object changes,
- Validation Criteria change,
- Validation Purpose changes,
- Validation Scope changes,
- Validation Method changes,
- object configuration changes,
- new contextual information emerges,
- or the evidentiary relationship is better understood.

Material relevance changes must remain traceable.

Minimum Implementation Framework

1. Establish Evidence Requirement

Identify the specific Validation Criterion and evidentiary requirement the candidate evidence is expected to support.

2. Identify Candidate Evidence

Establish the evidence item or evidence body proposed for validation use.

3. Establish Relevance Relationship

Determine its relationship to:

- Validation Object,
- Validation Criterion,
- evidence requirement,
- Validation Method,
- Validation Purpose,
- and Validation Scope.

4. Classify Relevance Type

Where applicable, distinguish:

- direct,
- indirect,
- supporting,
- contextual,
- conditional,
- or irrelevant evidence.

5. Establish Relevance Boundary

Determine the conditions within which the evidence remains relevant and prevent unsupported transfer beyond those conditions.

6. Establish Relevance Status

Classify the evidence as:

- Relevant,
- Conditionally Relevant,
- Relevance Undetermined,
- or Irrelevant.

7. Preserve Relevance Traceability

Maintain:

- Evidence Identifier,
- Validation Object reference,
- Validation Criterion reference,
- evidence requirement,
- relevance type,
- relevance rationale,
- applicable boundaries,
- conditions,
- limitations,
- conflicts,
- relevance status,
- version,
- changes,
- and sufficient lifecycle traceability.

Relevance Output

VERM may produce:

- Evidence Relevance Record,
- Evidence-to-Criterion Map,
- Evidence Requirement Link,
- Relevance Classification,
- Relevance Boundary,
- Conditional Relevance Record,
- Relevance Conflict Record,
- Irrelevant Evidence Exclusion Record,
- and Evidence Relevance Determination.

These outputs become inputs into subsequent Evidence Fitness governance.

Use Case 1 — AI Safety Validation

Scenario

An organization provides extensive benchmark-performance results as evidence that an AI system is safe for autonomous operation.

Application VERM maps the benchmark evidence against the Validation Criteria.

The results are directly relevant to performance criteria but provide only limited or no direct relevance to several autonomous safety criteria.

Result

The benchmark evidence remains valid evidence for the conditions it actually addresses, but it cannot be used to create artificial

coverage of unrelated safety requirements.

Use Case 2 — Healthcare AI

Scenario

A diagnostic AI system is intended for deployment across multiple patient populations.

Evidence comes primarily from one population.

Application

VERM determines that the evidence is directly relevant to performance within the represented population but only conditionally relevant to other materially different populations.

Result

The evidence cannot silently be generalized across the complete Validation Scope.

Architectural Position

Validation Evidence Relevance is the first internal governance space of the **Validation Evidence Fitness Standard (VEFS)**.

It establishes the first transformation:

Available Information → Candidate Evidence → Relevant Validation Evidence

Subsequent Evidence Fitness governance can then determine whether that relevant evidence is sufficiently applicable, complete, representative, timely, and otherwise fit for the governed validation role.

Foundational Principle

Evidence cannot support a validation question that it does not meaningfully address.

Canonical Closing Statement

Validation Evidence Relevance Module establishes the first evidence-qualification gate within VALIDOS® by governing the relationship between candidate evidence and the validation question it is expected to support. By governing object relevance, criterion relevance, requirement relevance, methodological relevance, purpose and scope alignment, direct and indirect support, contextual

contribution, relevance boundaries, transfer, conflict, exclusion, change, and traceability, VERM ensures that evidence enters validation because it meaningfully addresses a governed validation requirement—not merely because it exists, appears authoritative, or concerns the same general subject.

Parent Resources

→ [VALIDOS® Validation Governance Architecture — Validation Governance Layer](#)

→ [VALIDOS® Architecture Map](#)

→ [VALIDOS® Complete Standards & Modules Index](#)

Internal Module Flow

→ [Next module: Validation Evidence Applicability Module \(VEAM\)](#)

Related Documents

→ [Validation Evidence Fitness Standard](#)

→ [About Validation Evidence Fitness Standard](#)

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